Research Planning Rules

Selection function and operating rules for the monthly one-pager. Split: 80% research progress, 20% everything else.

1. Capture: the brain dump

- Every question, gap, or resource that comes up goes into the brain dump as one line, with a resource if known.
- Capturing is not pursuing. Write it down and return to the task.

2. Selection function (applied at the monthly review only)

An item qualifies if it meets at least one criterion:

- **A.** It touches research I am doing this month or next.
- **B.** It feeds a talk or paper on the calendar.
- **C.** It has appeared in the dump at least twice (recurrence separates a real gap from passing curiosity).

Rank qualifying items A, then B, then C. Fill the fixed slots in that order:

- **One foundations text or note set**, continued until finished. No parallel texts.
- **Four big-picture questions**, one per week, each closed by a one-to-two page derivation note.
- Nothing else is added. Unselected items stay in the dump for next month.

3. The 20% budget, in hours (40-hour research week)

- 5 x 1 hour: daily foundations slot, active work only (problems, derivations, numerical checks).
- 2 hours: weekly big-picture question.
- 1 hour: slack.
- Every item has a done criterion: pages and problems for a text, an existing note for a question. No done criterion, no slot.

4. Change rules

- The one-pager is frozen for the month.
- A question surfaced by research may replace a planned one **one-for-one, in the same slot**. No additions.
- Mid-work questions are pursued immediately only if they block progress for more than about 30 minutes, and then for one block only. Otherwise: dump it.
- Mid-month check (15 minutes): measure progress against the plan. Do not redesign the plan.

5. Measurement

- Log actual hours weekly by category (research vs. 20%). Drift should be visible within a week, not at month end.
- At the monthly review: compare logged split to 80/20, note what was finished, then apply the selection function to the dump.

The design is not the weak point. Commitment is. The frozen plan and the one-for-one swap are what make commitment possible.